



Shurūt al-Ṣalāh

It is obligatory to perform the following five prayers every day during the prescribed times:

1. Ṣalāt al-Fajr (Dawn prayer), which consists of two units (each unit of prayer is called a rak'ah)
2. Ṣalāt aẓ-Ẓuhr (Midday prayer), consisting of four units
3. Ṣalāt al-'Aṣr (Afternoon prayer), consisting of four units
4. Ṣalāt al-Maghrib (Dusk prayer), which consists of three units
5. Ṣalāt al-'Ishā' (Night prayer), consisting of four units

1. PROSTRATION ON EARTH

A brief text about why Shi'ah prostrate on the turbah or soil from Karbala.

Why do the Shi'ah prostrate on Turbah?

فَسَبِّحْ بِحَمْدِ رَبِّكَ وَكُن مِّن السَّاجِدِينَ ﴿٩٨﴾

98. Fa-sabbih bi-ḥamdi rabbika
wa-kun mina s-sājidīn(a)

98. So exalt with praise of your
Lord and be of those who
prostrate.

[Qur'an 15:98]

The Shi'ah Muslims prefer to prostrate on a small block of earth, called a Turbah, which is usually made from clay from the land of Karbala in Iraq. According to the Shi'ah Ja'fari fiqh - which is one of the five main schools of law in Islam - prostration must be performed on pure earth or what grows on it, provided that it is not eaten or worn. This includes dust, stone, sand and grass, provided that it is not a mineral. Prostration on paper is permitted, because it is made of a material which grows on earth, but not cloth or carpets. The legal scholars of all the Sunni schools of law concur regarding the validity of prostration on earth and that which grows on it.

Did the Prophet (s) and his Companions ever do this?

Praying on the earth was certainly the practice of the Prophet (s) and those around him.

- Narrated Abu Sa'id al-Khudri: I saw Allah's Apostle prostrating in mud and water and saw the mark of mud on his forehead.
[Al-Bukhārī, Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī (English translation), vol. 1, book 12, no. 798; vol. 3, book 33, no. 244]
- Narrated Anas bin Malik: We used to pray with the Prophet in scorching heat, and if someone of us could not put his face on the earth (because of the heat) then he would spread his clothes and prostrate over them.

[*Al-Bukhārī, Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī (English translation), vol. 2, book 22, no. 299*]

According to this hadith only in exceptional circumstances would the Prophet (s) and his Companions prostrate on cloth. The Prophet (s) also used to have a Khumra on which he would put his forehead for prostration.

- Narrated Maymuna: Allah's Apostle used to pray on a Khumra.
[*Al-Bukhārī, Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī (English translation), vol. 1, book 8, no. 378*]
- According to al-Shawkani, a famous Sunni scholar, more than ten Companions of the Prophet (s) have narrated traditions mentioning his prostration on a Khumrah. And he lists all the Sunni sources recording these traditions which include Sahih Muslim, Sahih al-Tirmidhi, Sunan Abu Dawud, Sunan al-Nasa'i and many others.
[*Al-Shawkani, Nayl al-Awtar, Chapter of Prostration on the Khumrah, vol. 2, p. 128*]

So what is a khumrah?

- A small mat sufficient just for the face and the hands while prostrating during prayers.
[*Al-Bukhārī, Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī (English translation), vol. 1, book 8, no. 376 (as explained by the translator in paranthesis)*]
- Ibn al-Athīr, another famous Sunni scholar, in his Jami al-'Usul has written:
"Khumra is [like that] upon which the Shi'ah of our time perform their prostrations."
[*Ibn al-Athīr, Jāmi' al-Uṣūl fī Aḥādīth al-Rasūl, (Cairo, 1969), vol. 5, p. 467*]
- "Khumra is a small mat made from palm fibres or other material.... and it is like that which the Shi'ah use for prostration."
[*Talkhīṣ al-Ṣiḥāḥ, p. 81*]

But why the earth of Karbala?

The special characteristics of the soil of Karbala (Iraq) were known and it was an object of special attention during the time of the Prophet (s) as well as in later times:

- Umm Salama says: I saw Husayn (a) sitting in the lap of his grandfather, the Prophet (s), who had a red block of soil in his hand. The Prophet (s) was kissing the dust and weeping. I asked him what that soil was. The Prophet (s) said: "Gabriel has informed me that my son, this Husayn, will be murdered in Iraq. He has brought this earth for me from that land. I am weeping for the suffering that will befall my Husayn." Then the Prophet (s) handed the dust to Umm Salama and said to her: "When you see this soil turn into blood, you will know that my Husayn has been slaughtered." Umm Salama kept the soil in a bottle and kept watch over it until she saw on the day of Ashura, 10th of Muharram 61 A.H., that it turned to blood. Then she knew that Husayn bin Ali (a) had been martyred.

[*Al-Hākim al-Naysābūrī, Al-Mustadrak 'alā al-Ṣaḥīḥayn, vol. 4, p. 398*]

[*Al-Dhahabī, Siyar A'lām al-Nubalā', vol. 3, p. 194*]

[*Ibn Kathīr, Al-Bidāyah wa'l-Nihāyah fī al-Tārikh, vol. 6, p. 230*]

[*Al-Suyūṭī, Khaṣā'is al-Kubrā, vol. 2, p. 450; Jam' al-Jawami, vol. 1, p. 26*]

[*Ibn Hajar al-Asqalānī, Tahdhīb al-Tahdhīb, vol. 2, p. 346*]

- 'Ali ibn Abi Talib, passed by Karbala after the battle of Siffin. He took a handful of its soil and exclaimed: 'Ah, ah, on this spot some men will be slain, and will enter Paradise without reckoning!'

[*Ibn Hajar al-Asqalānī, Tahdhīb al-Tahdhīb, vol. 2, p. 348*]

Why is it compulsory to prostrate on the clay from Karbala?

It is not!

But the Shi'ah prefer to prostrate on the earth of Karbala because of the

importance given to it by the Prophet (s) and the Imams from his Family (Ahl al-Bayt). After the martyrdom of Imam Husayn (a), his son Imam Zayn al-'Abidin (a) picked some up, declared it to be sacred dust, and kept it in a bag. The Imams (a) used to perform prostrations on it and make a tasbeeh out of it, and recited Allah's praises on it.

[Ibn Shahrāshūb, *Al-Manāqib Āl Abī Ṭālib*, vol. 2, p. 251]

They also encouraged the Shi'ah to perform prostrations on them, with the understanding that it was not compulsory, but with a view to achieving greater recompense. The Imams (a) insisted that prostration before Allah must be on clean earth only and that it was preferable if it was performed on that earth of Karbala.

[*Al-Ṭūsī, Miṣbāḥ al-Mutahajjid wa-Silāḥ al-Muta'abbid*, p. 511]

[*Shaykh al-Ṣadūq, Man lā yaḥḍuruḥu l-faqīh*, vol. 1, p. 174]

The Shi'ah for a long time have kept this earth with them. Then, fearing that it might be desecrated, they kneaded it into small tablets or pieces, which are now called mohr or Turbah. During prayers we prostrate on it not as a compulsory act but in view of its special nature. Otherwise, when we have no pure soil with us, we prostrate on clean earth, or something that originates from it.

It is a pity that some people maliciously insist that the Shi'ah worship stones or that they worship Husayn (a). The truth is that we worship Allah alone by prostrating on the Turbah, not to it. And we never worship Imam Husayn, Imam Ali, or the Prophet Muḥammad (s). We worship only Allah, and it is in accordance with Allah's order that we perform prostration only on pure earth.

Conclusion

This is the reason why Shi'ah Muslims carry small tablets, usually made from the earth of Karbala, which enables them to do prostration on this highly recommended object and to follow the sunnah of the Prophet (s).

2. Pray in Arabic

Why pray in Arabic?

The question sometimes is asked as to why should a Muslim pray only in Arabic language and not his mother tongue. It may first seem logical that every Muslim should pray through his own mother language, so that he may understand what he say; but a little more thinking and study, we shall find that there are strong arguments in favour of only one common language and that also Arabic.

Arabic: A deep and vast Language

It is a fact recognized by the linguists that the Arabic language has the best ability to express wide and deep thoughts and to explain important subjects in short and precise words. Moreover, it has been proved that no language, except Arabic, is capable of presenting such deep spiritual, moral and ethical expressions in such an eloquent manner. Therefore the choice of Arabic for Islamic prayers is not to be wondered upon.

Veccia Vaglieri, an Italian orientalist in the University of Naples, writes in her book on Advancement of Islam, that in no literary work of the world can there be found such deep-meaning sentences with such beautiful words except in the Qur'an; and that depth of meaning is crowned with such eloquent language.

The late George Bernard Shaw, in the course of his discussion on Islam at Mombasa during 1943 said: "I also very much admire the forcible and striking diction of the Qur'an. What grace and beauty characterizes that passage which depicts the dreadful scene of the dooms-day field, and dealing with infanticide, dramatically leaves off at the question, 'For what crime wert thou slain?' to the innocent child that was buried alive or put to death. In my opinion it is the most effective way of creating an abiding impression on the minds of people."

Professor Arbury, the well known orientalist scholar (University of Cambridge), says that no language has and shall have the ability to put in a short sentence, the word من (Min) (which is repeated five times in an ayat of the Qur'an) without disturbing the eloquence and conveyance of its meaning, except the language (Arabic) which is chosen for the Qur'an to convey the message of Islam.

A Common Language for the Islamic Prayer

All Muslims perform their religious rites and worship of God, including the daily five time prayers, in Arabic. In the course of these prayers, some verses of the Qur'an and other sentences, are uttered so as to express the Greatness and Glory of Allah, the Creator, and the humbleness and insignificance of the human beings, the creatures. This is done in the same wordings by all Muslims, Arabs and non-Arabs alike, even by those who do not understand Arabic. This system of prayers in one common language was in practice during the life time of the Prophet of Islam and has continued after him for more than 1400 years. In every country, Muslims have been praying in Arabic language.

Cementing the Islamic Brotherhood

Prayer in Arabic cements the Islamic brotherhood and emphasizes the universal character of Islam. Islam has come for the entire Human race. It is a fact that the Muslim Communities of the world, like all other communities, speak numerous languages and dialects. At the same time it should be appreciated that our life today is rapidly assuming international character. Distance between any two points of the world has shrunk fantastically. In every place you will find Muslims speaking different languages. Imagine a Muslim who is an Englishman going to China and passing through a street. Suddenly he hears the voice of, say 'ching-chang-chung' which, let us suppose mean 'Allahu Akbar' - Allah is the Greatest. No doubt the stranger would not understand that it is a call

for Muslim prayer and would miss the opportunity of praying in congregation with the people of that locality.

Incidentally, the mosques in China do not resemble in appearance to those in Europe or other Eastern countries and are without minarets. Conversely, if a Chinese travels abroad where people pray in their local language, he would not be able to understand it and participate in it.

Sayyid Sa'eed Akhtar Rizvi, Chief Missionary of Bilal Muslim Mission, writes:

"Prayers in Arabic are an important factor cementing the solidity and unity of Muslims all over the world. Nowadays if a Muslim from Czechoslovakia enters a mosque in the interior of Congo, he finds himself at home and participates in the prayer without any hint of bewilderment. What will happen if every man is told to pray in his own language? Can this feeling of Unity and Oneness survive?"

Thus, Islam, the universal religion, has paved the way of common approach to God, has united its followers and instilled in them a feeling of everlasting Brotherhood. One cannot ignore the racial, colour, or national prejudices which are rife these days almost in every country, Islam has not only condemned all sorts of discrimination but has shown the practical way of fostering fraternity and brotherhood. A common language for religious services plays a great part in bringing people close to one another and create a feeling of equality in the eyes of God.

Qur'an, Work of Allah

Arabic in which the Holy Qur'an and traditions of the Prophet have been revealed has a special status and honour. This high status of Arabic is not due to its being the language of the Arabs; rather it is because of its being language of Qur'an chosen by Almighty God for conveying His last message and revelation.

Muslims believe that the Holy Qur'an is the Word of God. As such, it is only befitting that the recitation of the word of God is done in the same form and language in which it was originally pronounced. Spiritually, a

faithful Muslim finds himself ascending higher and higher with the support of the words of God as expressed in the original language which is Arabic.

Translation almost Impossible

Any translation of the original will not be the word of God but the work of human beings. Keep in view the imperfect human knowledge, and remember that Arabic is the widest and richest of all languages. Then you will have to admit that no translation of the Qur'an would be perfect enough to carry the true meanings and to fulfill the spiritual purposes.

Sayyid Sa'eed Akhtar Rizvi writes on this subject:

"Praying in English: First of all, translation of any work of literature from any language into another is considered by all men of literature as almost impossible. Of course, you will find thousands of translations of literary works, but they represent only the body of the original; the spirit is always lost.

Secondly, Arabic language, in particular, is so comprehensive that, for example, it is just impossible to convey the complete idea of a word (let alone a 'sentence') into English. Take for example, the most common phrase الحمد لله which is generally translated as "All praise be to God." Now الحمد لله conveys in Arabic the following shades of meaning:

1. Each and every individual of the thing mentioned, taken separately;
2. All the individuals of the thing mentioned taken jointly;
3. The species of the thing mentioned taken as an abstract idea etc.

Now if you want to translate الحمد لله in such a way as to convey all the meanings mentioned above you will have to say 'Each and every, all and the.'

Then comes حمد . There is not a single word in English to convey its idea. 'Praise' is translation of حمد not مدح ; Thanks' is translation of شكر not حمد.

"Hamd" means "to praise and thank someone because he deserves to be praised whether he has done you any favour or not provided that his qualities are not given to him by someone else." How can anybody convey this idea in translations?

Now comes (L) of الله It conveys the idea of 'For', 'Of', 'Belonging to' etc. No single English preposition can cover the whole range of its meanings. الله is generally rendered as 'God'. But, first of all 'god' is not translation of الله because الله means 'One who deserves to be loved' and 'Into whom every one seeks refuge.' Secondly الله has no plural and no feminine. So this name itself reflects light upon the fact that He is one and only "one and that He has no partner nor any equal. But "god" has plural (gods) and feminine (goddess).

This short explanation should be sufficient to show that it is impossible to translate the Qur'an in such a way that the translation conveys all the shades of meanings of the original".

In the words of A. J. Arberry, the Qur'an is "a foreign idiom, for the Qur'an is God's revelation in Arabic, and the emotive and evocative qualities of the original disappear almost totally in the most skilful translation."
[A. J. Arberry, *The Holy Qur'an: An Introduction with Selections* (published London, 1953)]

It is clear, therefore, that no translation can replace this, divine literary work at all. Of course, a number of English translations of the Qur'an have been published; but it has always been felt that yet another effort for better translation is necessary, because all existing translations appear inadequate or carrying misleading meanings of certain verses. This feeling is not restricted to English translations; but it affects also those in other languages. Under the circumstances, should one make use of the defective translation and leave aside the perfect original, particularly when he is addressing the Almighty Allah?

3. Ablution

Introduction

Performing the Daily Prayers according to the Shi'ah Ja'fari school of law involves taking prescribed steps in order (tartib) and in regular succession without undue delay between them (muwalat). The person must first perform preliminary purification (ghusl, if necessary, or wudhu) and fulfil all other prerequisites.

One of the tasks of all prophets (a) in general and of the Noble Prophet of Islam (s) in particular was to purify people. Regarding this, Sūrah 62 reads:

هُوَ الَّذِي بَعَثَ فِي الْأُمِّيِّينَ رَسُولًا مِنْهُمْ يَتْلُو عَلَيْهِمْ آيَاتِهِ وَيُزَكِّيهِمْ وَيُعَلِّمُهُمُ
الْكِتَابَ وَالْحِكْمَةَ وَإِنْ كَانُوا مِنْ قَبْلُ لَفِي ضَلَالٍ مُبِينٍ ﴿٢﴾

2. Huwa lladhī ba'atha fī l-'ummiyyīna rasūlan minhum yatlu 'alayhim 'āyātihī wa-yuzakkīhim wa-yu'allimuhumu l-kitāba wa-l-ḥikmata wa-'in kānū min qablu la-fī ḍalālin mubīn(in) –

2. It is He who has sent among the Ummiyyīn a Rasūl sawaw from them reciting to them His Āyāt and lauds their purity and teaching them the Book and wisdom – and even before they were not in manifest error –

[Qur'an 62:2. (Ummiyyīn means 'People of Ummul Qura : Makkah')]

This fact has also been referred to in three other ayat of the Glorious Qur'an. Among these tasks, purification holds an important position and indeed it is the summation of the whole mission of the Noble Prophet (s). He has the ability to purify other people because he is already purified, as Sūrah 33 explains:

...إِنَّمَا يُرِيدُ اللَّهُ لِيُذْهِبَ عَنْكُمُ الرِّجْسَ أَهْلَ الْبَيْتِ وَيُطَهِّرَكُمْ تَطْهِيرًا (٣٣)

33. ...'innamā yurīdu llāhu li-yudhhiba 'ankumu r-rijsa 'ahla l-bayti wa-yuṭahhirakum taṭhīra(n)

33. ...Allāh intends only to keep away from you all impurity, O people of the household, and to keep you pure – a thorough purification.

[Qur'an 33:33]

It should be mentioned that the Infallibles (a) were pure due to their own actions; and God then made them thoroughly and completely purified. One should do one's best to become pure; and then God purifies one completely because complete purification cannot be achieved without divine assistance. Hence, in the Glorious Qur'an, a distinction has been made between mutahhar (the one who has been purified [by God]) and mutatahhir (the one who seeks purification through his actions). Some people have also been described in the Glorious Qur'an as those seeking purity (tazakka) and some people as those who are purified (muzakka). In the same way, some individuals seek closeness (taqarrub) to God and there are some who are brought near (muqarrab) to Him (swt). Therefore, one should make the utmost efforts to become purified as much as one is able to do so. As a metaphor, a man who wants to visit a king approaches as close as he can by himself, however, eventually he reaches a point at which he cannot make any more progress, and the king himself has to take him in. In any case, the mission of the Noble Prophet (s) is to purify people. However, he (s) is not able to do so unless people themselves desire this.

According to many exegetes of the Glorious Qur'an, ayah 108 of Sūrah Tawbah has been revealed regarding the Quba mosque in Medina. This ayah reads:

لَا تَقُمْ فِيهِ أَبَدًا ۚ لَمَْسْجِدٌ أُسِّسَ عَلَى التَّقْوَىٰ مِنْ أَوَّلِ يَوْمٍ ۖ أَحَقُّ أَنْ تَقُومَ فِيهِ ۚ فِيهِ
 رِجَالٌ يُحِبُّونَ أَنْ يَتَطَهَّرُوا ۚ وَاللَّهُ يُحِبُّ الْمُطَهَّرِينَ ﴿١٠٨﴾

108. Lā taqum fīhi 'abadan la-
 masjidun 'ussisa 'alā t-taqwā min
 'awwali yawmin 'aḥaqqu 'an
 taqūma fīhi fīhi rijālun yuḥibbūna
 'an yataṭahharū wa-llāhu yuḥibbu l-
 muṭṭahhirīn(a)

108. Do not stand within it – ever.
 A Masjid founded on God-
 consciousness from the first day
 is more worthy for you to stand in.
 Within it are men who love to
 purify themselves; and Allāh loves
 those who purify themselves.

[Qur'an 9:108]

This description of the Quba mosque is in direct contrast to the Qirar mosque, which was built in Medina by the hypocrites in order for them to create problems for the Muslim community. According to this ayah, there are some righteous people who intend to be purified and God loves those who, although not yet pure, are seeking to be purified. So, those with bad qualities and bad moral characters fall into the category of those whom God loves as long as they earnestly desire and seek to remove them and attain purification. Thus, the Noble Prophet (s) is commanded to say his prayer in a mosque where there are those who want to be purified, not in a mosque where nobody has such an intention. Along the same lines, Sūrah 87 reads:

قَدْ أَفْلَحَ مَنْ تَزَكَّى ﴿١٤﴾

14. Qad 'aflaḥa man tazakkā

14. Has already succeeds the one
 who purifies himself –

[Qur'an 87:14]

Man tazakka means the one who seeks purity. One of the ways to reach this goal is to give alms (zakat) because when one gives one's money and property for the sake of God one removes love of worldly affairs from

oneself, which is the major source of corruption and pollution. Imam Sajjad (a) has indicated this in the following phrase:

...حُبُّ الدُّنْيَا رَأْسُ كُلِّ خَطِيئَةٍ ۝ وَالْدُّنْيَا دُنْيَاءَانِ: دُنْيَا بَلَإٍ ۝ وَدُنْيَا
مَلْعُونَةٍ

...Hubbu ad-dunyā ra'su kulli
khaṭī'ah, wa-ad-dunyā dunyā'ān:
dunyā balāghin, wa-dunyā
mal'ūnah.

...Love of this world is the head of
every sin, and the world is of two
kinds:
a world that brings [divine]
attainment,
and a cursed world.

[Al-Kafi, Vol.2, H 2580, CH.122, h 8]

The Significance Of Wudu' In The Process Of Purification

In any case, all Prophets (a) have been sent by God to humankind in order to help them in the process of purification. Prayer is the best means of attaining such a precious goal and after this comes zakat. Prayer and giving alms have been mentioned jointly in numerous ayat of the Glorious Qur'an. Seeking purity through prayer alone and without giving alms is impossible and vice versa; rather, both of them together are necessary. In order for us to attain purity through prayer, God has ordered us to do some physical actions which bring about some experience of purity. The best example of these actions is ablution (wudu').

In reference to this, Sūrah 5 reads:

يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا إِذَا قُمْتُمْ إِلَى الصَّلَاةِ فَاغْسِلُوا وُجُوهَكُمْ وَأَيْدِيَكُمْ إِلَى
الْمَرَافِقِ وَامْسَحُوا بِرُءُوسِكُمْ وَأَرْجُلَكُمْ إِلَى الْكَعْبَيْنِ وَإِنْ كُنْتُمْ جُنُبًا فَاطَّهَّرُوا
وَإِنْ كُنْتُمْ مَرْضَىٰ أَوْ عَلَىٰ سَفَرٍ أَوْ جَاءَ أَحَدٌ مِنْكُمْ مِنَ الْغَائِطِ أَوْ لَامَسْتُمُ

النِّسَاءَ فَلَمْ تَجِدُوا مَاءً فَتَيَمَّمُوا صَعِيدًا طَيِّبًا فَامْسَحُوا بِوُجُوهِكُمْ وَأَيْدِيكُمْ
 مِنْهُ مَا يُرِيدُ اللَّهُ لِيَجْعَلَ عَلَيْكُمْ مِنْ حَرَجٍ وَلَكِنْ يُرِيدُ لِيُطَهِّرَكُمْ وَلِيُتِمَّ
 نِعْمَتَهُ عَلَيْكُمْ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَشْكُرُونَ ﴿٦﴾

6. Yā-'ayyuhā lladhīna 'āmanū 'idhā qumtum 'ilā ṣ-ṣalāti fa-ghsilū wujūhakum wa-'aydiyakum 'ilā l-marāfiqi wa-msaḥū bi-ru'ūsikum wa-'arjulakum 'ilā l-ka'bayni wa-'in kuntum junuban fa-tṭahharū wa-'in kuntum marḍā 'aw 'alā safarin 'aw jā'a 'aḥadun minkum mina l-ghā'itī 'aw lāmastumu n-nisā'a fa-lam tajidū mā'an fa-tayammamū ṣa'īdan ṭayyiban fa-msaḥū bi-wujūhikum wa-'aydikum minhu mā yurīdu llāhu li-yaj'ala 'alaykum min ḥarajin wa-lākin yurīdu li-yuṭahhirakum wa-li-yutimma ni'matahū 'alaykum la'allakum tashkurūn(a)

6. O you who believe, when you rise to [perform] prayer, wash your faces and your forearms up to the elbows and wipe over [front part of] your heads and your feet up to the ankles. And if you are in a state of Janabah, then purify yourselves [with bath]. But if you are ill or on a journey or one of you comes from the place of relieving himself or you have contacted women and do not find water, then do Tayammum with clean earth and wipe [with dust] over your faces and hands with it. Allāh does not intend to make difficulty for you, but He intends to purify you and complete His favor upon you that you may be grateful.

[Qur'an 5:6]

According to this ayah, purification is the main goal of making wudu' and tayammum (dry ablution). It is a mistake to assume that in the ayah purity refers to physical purity through washing some parts of the body since such a thing does not occur in tayammum. It is a preliminary condition to make the areas on which wudu' will be performed clean before starting wudu', which then gives us spiritual purity. Tayammum also has the same function. The phrase 'and to complete His blessing upon you' in the above ayah refers to a very subtle point. The blessings of God are completed by purity. Thus, wudu' has been designed by God in such a way that one can experience some form of purity while one is not still a completely pure

person. As long as one keeps one's wudu', one possess a manifestation of purity. This is a great blessing from God because through an easy action like wudu' one may attain a kind of purity, albeit partially. It is difficult for ordinary people to distinguish between being in a state of wudu' or not. However, those whose inner vision is opened are able to realise how different they are when in the state of ablution.

The Light Of Wudu'

Many people may not be able to witness such a light, yet they should not reject the reality of such a light since this fact has been confirmed in several narrations by the Noble Prophet (s) and his purified progeny. One of the Infallibles (a) has been quoted as saying:

الوضوء على الوضوء نور على نور

Al-wuḍū' 'alā al-wuḍū' nūrun 'alā nūr

Ablution upon ablution is light upon light.

[Shaykh Hurr al-'Amili, *Wasa'il al-Shi'a*, (Qom: Mu'assasah Al al-Bayt Lilhya' al- Turath, 1409 A.H.) vol. 1, 377, no. 8. Shaykh Hurr cites this hadith from *Man La Yahduruh al-Faqih* where the name of the Infallible to whom this hadith belongs has not been mentioned, but in *'Awali al-La'ali*, vol. 2, p. 170, this hadith has been attributed to the Prophet (s).]

Status of Water Used for Wudu'

Interestingly, the water used for making ablution is blessed. Although it is initially normal water, when it is used for wudu' it receives a different reality. This water turns into drops of light and this light is then put onto the relevant parts of one's body when one makes ablution. According to the history of early Islam, being aware of the blessings contained in the

water used for wudu', Muslims used to catch the water dripping from the face and hands of the Noble Prophet (s) while he was making wudu'. It has been reported that they did not allow a single drop of that water to be wasted.

According to a passage in Misbah al-Shari'ah, Imam al-Sadiq (a) is reported to have said:

إذا أردت الطهارة والوضوء • فتقدم إلى الماء تقدمك إلى رحمة الله • فإن الله -
تعالى - قد جعل الماء مفتاح قُربته ومناجاته • ووسيلةً إلى بساط خدمته.
وكما أن رحمة الله تُطهرُ ذنوبَ العباد • كذلك التَّجاسُاتُ الظَّاهرة يُطهرُها
الماءُ لا غير. قال تعالى: ﴿ وَهُوَ الَّذِي أَرْسَلَ الرِّيحَ بُشْرًا بَيْنَ يَدَيْ رَحْمَتِهِ وَأَنْزَلْنَا
مِنَ السَّمَاءِ مَاءً طَهُورًا ﴾. وقال تعالى: ﴿ وَجَعَلْنَا مِنَ الْمَاءِ كُلَّ شَيْءٍ حَيٍّ أَفَلَا
يُؤْمِنُونَ ﴾. فكما أحيأ به كُلَّ شَيْءٍ من نعيم الدنيا • كذلك بفضله ورحمته
جعل حياة القلوب بالطَّاعات. وتفكَّرْ في صفاء الماء ورقته وطهوره وبركته •
ولطيف امتزاجه بكلِّ شَيْءٍ • وفي كُلِّ شَيْءٍ. واستعمله في تطهير الأعضاء
التي أمرك الله بتطهيرها • وائتِ بآدابها وفرائضها وسننها • فإن تحت كُلِّ
واحدةٍ منها فوائد كثيرة • إذا استعملتها بالحرمة • انفجرت لك عينُ فوائدها
عن قريب. ثم عاشَرْ خلقَ الله تعالى كامتزاج الماء بالأشياء: يؤدِّي كُلُّ شَيْءٍ
حقَّه • ولا يتغيَّر عن معناه. معتبراً لقول الرسول (ص): «مَثَلُ الْمُؤْمِنِ
الْخَالِصِ كَمَثَلِ الْمَاءِ»

Idhā aradta ṭ-ṭahārah wa-l-wuḍū',
fataqaddam ilā l-mā'i
taqaddumaka ilā raḥmati Llāh, fa-

When you seek purification and
ablution, approach the water as
you would approach the mercy of

inna Llāha – ta‘ālā – qad ja‘ala l-mā’a miftāḥa qurbatihi wa-munājātihi, wa-wasīlata ilā bisāṭi khidmatihi. Wa-kamā anna raḥmata Llāh tuṭahhiru dhunūba l-‘ibād, ka-dhālika n-najasātu ḡ-ḡāhirah yuṭahhiruhā l-mā’u lā ghayruh.

Qāla ta‘ālā: “Wa-huwa lladhī arsala r-rīāḥa bushran bayna yaday raḥmatihi wa-anzalnā mina s-samā’i mā’an ṭahūran”

Wa-qāla ta‘ālā: “Wa-ja‘alnā mina l-mā’i kulla shay’in ḡayy; afalā yu‘minūn”

Fa-kamā aḡyā bihi kulla shay’in min na‘īmi d-dunyā, ka-dhālika bi-faḍlihi wa-raḥmatihi ja‘ala ḡayāta l-qulūbi bi-ṭ-ṭā‘āt. Wa-tafakkar fī ṣafā’i l-mā’i wa-raqqatihi wa-ṭuhūrihi wa-barakatihi wa-laṭīfi imtizājihi bi-kulli shay’in wa-fī kulli shay’. Wa-sta‘milhu fī taṭhīri l-a‘ḡḡā’i allatī amaraka Llāhu bi-taṭhīrihā, wa-ti bi-ādābihā wa-farā’idihā wa-sunanihā, fa-inna taḡta kulli wāḡidatin minhā fawā’ida kathīrah, idhā ista‘maltahā bi-l-ḡurmah infaḡarat laka ‘aynu fawā’idihā ‘an qarīb. Thumma ‘āshir khalqa Llāhi ta‘ālā ka-imtizāji l-mā’i bi-l-ashyā’: yu‘addī kulla shay’in ḡaqqah, wa-lā yataghayyaru ‘an ma’nāḡ, mu‘tabiran li-qawli r-rasūl (ṣ):

“Mathalu l-mu‘mini l-khālīṣ ka-mathali l-mā’”

God. For indeed, God the Exalted has made water the key to His nearness and intimate conversation, and a means to reach the carpet of His service. Just as the mercy of God purifies the sins of His servants, so too does visible impurity find no purifier but water.

Allah said: “And it is He who sends the winds as glad tidings before His mercy, and We send down from the sky pure water.” (Qur’ān 25:48)

And He said: “And We made from water every living thing. Will they not then believe?” (Qur’ān 21:30)

So ust as He gave life to all things of worldly delight through water, likewise, through His grace and mercy, He granted life to hearts through obedience. Reflect on the clarity, delicacy, purity, and blessing of water, and how gently it mingles with everything, becoming part of all things. Use it to purify the limbs God commanded you to cleanse, and fulfill the etiquettes, obligations, and recommended acts of wuḡū’. For under each of these acts lies great wisdom; if you practice them with reverence, their hidden benefits will soon burst forth for you like a spring. Then, interact with God’s creation like water mingles with things—giving each

its due without losing its own essence, taking heed of the Prophet's saying:

"The example of a sincere believer is like that of water."

[Imam Sadiq, Misbah al-Shari'ah, (Tehran: Anjoman-e Hikmat va Falsafeh, 1360 A.H.S.) 43, verse 10. This is a valuable book attributed to Imam Sadiq (a), which has been accepted by Shi'ite scholars as a reliable source due to the profound content and ideas it contains, even though the chain of narratives is not completely authentic.]

According to the above-mentioned narration, water can be regarded as a symbol for living with other people. If water is poured in a dish, glass, jar, pot or anything else, it takes on the shape of its container but remains as water. A believer should be the same. If one finds oneself in a shop, office, school, bus, mosque, bank or anywhere else, facing good and bad circumstances, Muslim or non-Muslim people, one should remain a believer.

The Merits Of Wudu' As Mentioned In A Prophetic Narration

Once, two people went to the Noble Prophet (s) after the Morning Prayer when he used to sit in the mosque, answering peoples' questions. He asked them, 'Do you want me to tell what your questions are?' 'Yes,' they replied. 'It would bring us more certainty.' The Prophet said, 'One of you has a question about wudu' and its significance and the question of the other is about pilgrimage (hajj and 'umrah).' Then regarding wudu' he said:

فَاعْلَمْ أَنَّكَ إِذَا ضَرَبْتَ يَدَكَ فِي الْمَاءِ وَقُلْتَ: بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ تَنَاقَرَتِ
الدُّنُوبُ الَّتِي اكْتَسَبَتْهَا يَدَاكَ ۖ فَإِذَا غَسَلْتَ وَجْهَكَ تَنَاقَرَتِ الدُّنُوبُ الَّتِي

اَكْتَسَبَتْهَا عَيْنَاكَ بِنَظَرِهِمَا • وَفُوكَ بِلَفْظِهِ • فَإِذَا غَسَلْتَ ذِرَاعَيْكَ تَنَازَرَتِ
 الذُّنُوبُ عَنْ يَمِينِكَ وَشِمَالِكَ • فَإِذَا مَسَحْتَ رَأْسَكَ وَقَدَمَيْكَ تَنَازَرَتِ الذُّنُوبُ
 الَّتِي مَشَيْتَ إِلَيْهَا عَلَى قَدَمَيْكَ. فَهَذَا لَكَ فِي وُضُوءِكَ. فَإِذَا قُمْتَ إِلَى الصَّلَاةِ
 وَتَوَجَّهْتَ • وَقَرَأْتَ أَمَّ الْكِتَابِ وَمَا تَيَسَّرَ لَكَ مِنَ السُّورِ • ثُمَّ رَكَعْتَ فَأَتَمَمْتَ
 رُكُوعَهَا وَسُجُودَهَا • وَتَشَهَّدْتَ وَسَلَّمْتَ • غُفِرَ لَكَ كُلُّ ذَنْبٍ فِيمَا بَيْنَكَ وَبَيْنَ
 الصَّلَاةِ الَّتِي قَدَّمْتَهَا إِلَى الصَّلَاةِ الْمُؤَخَّرَةِ. فَهَذَا لَكَ فِي صَلَاتِكَ.

Fa'lam annaka idhā ɗarabta
 yadaka fī l-mā' wa-qulta: Bismi
 Llāhi r-Raḥmāni r-Raḥīm,
 tanātharat adh-dhunūbu allatī
 iktasabat-hā yadāk.

Fa-idhā ghasalta wajhaka
 tanātharat adh-dhunūbu allatī
 iktasabat-hā 'aynāk bi-naẓrihimā
 wa-fūka bi-lafẓih.

Fa-idhā ghasalta dhirā'ayk
 tanātharat adh-dhunūbu 'an
 yamīnika wa-shimālik.

Fa-idhā masaḥta ra'saka wa-
 qadamayk tanātharat adh-
 dhunūbu allatī mashayta ilayhā
 'alā qadamayk.

Fa-hādhā laka fī wuḍū'ik.

Fa-idhā qumta ilā ṣ-ṣalāh wa-
 tawajjhta wa-qara'ta Umm al-Kitāb
 wa-mā tayassara laka mina s-
 suwar, thumma raka'ta fa-
 atmamta rukū'ahā wa-sujūdathā
 wa-tashahhudta wa-sallamta,
 ghufira laka kullu dhanbin baynaka
 wa-bayna ṣ-ṣalāti allatī

Know that when you strike your
 hand into the water and say: "In
 the name of Allah, the Most
 Merciful, the Most
 Compassionate," the sins your
 hands have committed scatter
 away.

When you wash your face, the sins
 committed by your eyes through
 looking and by your mouth
 through speech fall away.

When you wash your arms, the
 sins from your right and left side
 fall away.

When you wipe your head and
 your feet, the sins of the places
 your feet have walked to fall away.

This is the benefit for you in your
 ablution (wuḍū').

Then when you stand for prayer,
 face the qiblah, and recite the
 Opening Chapter (Umm al-Kitāb)
 and whatever is easy for you from
 the other chapters, then bow and
 complete your bowing and

qaddamtahā ilā ṣ-ṣalāti l-
mu'akhharah.

Fa-hādhā laka fī ṣalātik.

prostration, perform the
tashahhud and give salām — you
are forgiven every sin committed
between that prayer and the
previous one.

This is the benefit for you in your
prayer.

[Shaykh Muḥammad Hurr al-'Amili, Wasa'il al-Shi'a, 393, no. 12.]

However, even with all these virtues of wudu', there is still a problem; since we become polluted again after being purified through making ablution because we have not changed our nature. Thus, we are like a clean child who makes themselves dirty again after a few minutes and as long as the child keeps this habit, the child will remain nice and clean only for a few minutes at a time. Wudu' and prayer can make us pure, and this purity can potentially remain forever. However, this purity does not remain because we do something wrong. This is the reason why we have to purify ourselves again and again. Therefore, the purity of wudu' and tayammun should be appreciated. One has to regard wudu' as a great opportunity. Wudu' in itself is an act of worship by which God completes His blessings as He says in Sūrah 5, ayat 3, where Imamate has also been described as the completion of Allah's blessings. The similarity between wudu' and Imamate may lie in the fact that the philosophy of both is purification:

حُرِّمَتْ عَلَيْكُمُ الْمَيْتَةُ وَالْدَّمُ وَلَحْمُ الْخِنْزِيرِ وَمَا أُهْلَ لِغَيْرِ اللَّهِ بِهِ وَالْمُنْخَنِقَةُ
وَالْمَوْقُوذَةُ وَالْمُتَرَدِّيَةُ وَالنَّطِيحَةُ وَمَا أَكَلَ السَّبْعُ إِلَّا مَا ذَكَّيْتُمْ وَمَا ذُبِحَ عَلَى
النُّصَبِ وَأَنْ تَسْتَقْسِمُوا بِالْأَزْلَامِ ذَٰلِكُمْ فِسْقٌ الْيَوْمَ يَبْسُ الدِّينَ كَفَرُوا مِنْ
دِينِكُمْ فَلَا تَخْشَوْهُمْ وَاخْشَوْنِ الْيَوْمَ أَكْمَلْتُ لَكُمْ دِينَكُمْ وَأَتَمَمْتُ

عَلَيْكُمْ نِعْمَتِي وَرَضِيتُ لَكُمُ الْإِسْلَامَ دِينًا فَمَنِ اضْطُرَّ فِي مَخْمَصَةٍ غَيْرَ

مُتَجَانِفٍ لِإِثْمٍ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ غَفُورٌ رَحِيمٌ ﴿٣﴾

3. Hurrimat 'alaykumu l-maytatu wa-d-damu wa-laḥmu l-khinzīri wa-mā 'uhilla li-ghayri llāhi bihī wa-l-munkhaniqatu wa-l-mawqūdhatu wa-l-mutaraddiyatu wa-n-naṭīḥatu wa-mā 'akala s-sabu'u 'illā mā dhakkaytum wa-mā dhubiḥa 'alā n-nuṣubi wa-'an tastaqsimū bi-l-'azlāmi dhālikum fisqun-i l-yawma ya'isa lladhīna kafarū min dīnikum fa-lā takhshawhum wa-khshawni l-yawma 'akmaltu lakum dīnakum wa-'atmamtu 'alaykum ni'matī wa-raḍītu lakumu l-'islāma dīnan fa-mani ḍṭurra fī makhmaṣatin ghayra mutajānifin li-'ithmin fa-'inna llāha ghafūrun raḥīm(un)

3. Prohibited to you are dead animals and blood and the flesh of pig, and that [animal] which has been dedicated to other than Allāh, and [those animals] killed by strangling or by a violent blow or by a head-long fall or by the goring of horns, and those from which a wild animal has eaten, except what you slaughter [before its death], and those which are sacrificed on stone altars, and [prohibited is] that you seek decision through divining arrows. That is grave disobedience. This day those who disbelieve [in Wilayat e Ali swsa] have despaired of [defeating] your religion; so fear them not, but revere Me. This day I have perfected for you your religion [with Wilayat e Ali swsa] and completed My Ne'mat [favor] upon you and have approved for you Islam as religion. But whoever is forced by severe hunger with no inclination to sin — then indeed, Allāh is Forgiving and Merciful.

[Qur'an 5:3]

Therefore, every time one is going to make ablution, one should perform it with due respect towards this wudu'.

In a contemplative narration, the Noble Prophet (s) said:

يَحْشُرُ اللَّهُ عَزَّ وَجَلَّ أُمَّتِي يَوْمَ الْقِيَامَةِ بَيْنَ الْأُمَمِ غُرًّا مُجَلَّلِينَ مِنْ آثَارِ الْوُضُوءِ

Yahshuru Llāhu ‘azza wa-jalla
ummatī yawma l-qiyāmah bayna l-
umam ghurran muḥajjalīn min
āthāri l-wuḍū’

Allah, the Almighty and Majestic,
will resurrect my Ummah on the
Day of Judgment among all
nations with radiant faces and
limbs shining from the traces of
wuḍū’ (ablution).

[Majlisi, Bihar al-Anwar, (Beirut: Mu’assasah al-Wafa’, 1403 A.H.) vol. 77,
237, no. 11]

Furthermore, it is recommended for a person who is making ablution to
say while washing his face:

اللَّهُمَّ بَيِّضْ وَجْهِي يَوْمَ تَسْوَدُّ فِيهِ الْوُجُوهُ ۖ وَلَا تَسْوَدِّ وَجْهِي يَوْمَ تَبْيِضُ فِيهِ
الْوُجُوهُ

Allāhumma bayyiḍ wajhī yawma
taswaddu fīhi l-wujūh, wa-lā
tusawwid wajhī yawma tabyaḍḍu
fīhi l-wujūh

O Allah, brighten my face on the
Day when faces will turn dark, and
do not darken my face on the Day
when faces will shine bright.

[Shaykh Muḥammad Hurr al-Amili, Wasa’il al-Shi’a, 402, no. 1]

Therefore, it can be concluded that there are two kinds of faces visible on
the Day of Judgment. Describing these two, Sūrah 80, ayat 38-42 read:

وُجُوهُ يَوْمَئِذٍ مُّسْفِرَةٌ ۖ ضَاحِكَةٌ مُّسْتَبْشِرَةٌ ۖ وَوُجُوهُ يَوْمَئِذٍ عَلَيْنَا غَبَرَةٌ ۖ
تَرْهَقُهَا قَتَرَةٌ ۚ أُولَٰئِكَ هُمُ الْكَافِرَةُ الْفَجَرَةُ ۚ

38. Wujūhun yawma'idhin
musfira(tun)

39. Ḍāḥikatun mustabshira(tun)

40. Wa-wujūhun yawma'idhin
'alayhā ghabara(tun)

41. Tarhaquhā qatara(tun)

42. 'Ulā'ika humu l-kafaratu l-
fajara(tu)

38. Faces, that Day, will be radiant
—

39. Those laughing, those
rejoicing at good tidings.

40. And faces, that Day, upon
them will be dust.

41. A gloom will overwhelm it.

42. Those – they are the
disbelievers, the wicked.

[Qur'an 80:33-42]

Wudu' As Described On The Night Of The Mi'raj

The significance of wudu' may also be perceived from the narrations concerning the night journey of the Noble Prophet (s) to the heavens (known as the Mi'raj). In one part of His conversation to the Noble Prophet (s), God instructed him about how to make ablution and enumerated some of its merits:

قال لي ربّي تعالى: يا مُحَمَّدٌ • مَدَّ يَدَكَ فَيَتَلَقَّاكَ مَاءٌ يَسِيلُ مِنْ سَاقِ الْعَرْشِ
الْأَيْمَنِ • فَتَنْزَلَ الْمَاءُ فَتَلْقَيْتُهُ بِالْيَمِينِ • فَمِنْ أَجْلِ ذَلِكَ صَارَ أَوَّلُ الْوُضُوءِ
الْيُمْنَى. ثُمَّ قَالَ: يَا مُحَمَّدٌ • خُذْ ذَلِكَ الْمَاءَ فَاغْسِلْ بِهِ وَجْهَكَ • وَعَلِمَهُ غَسَلَ
الْوَجْهَ • فَإِنَّكَ تُرِيدُ أَنْ تَنْظُرَ إِلَى عَظَمَتِي وَأَنْتَ طَاهِرٌ. ثُمَّ اغْسِلْ ذِرَاعَيْكَ
الْيَمِينَ وَالْيَسَارَ • وَعَلِمَهُ ذَلِكَ • فَإِنَّكَ تُرِيدُ أَنْ تَتَلَقَّى بِيَدَيْكَ كَلَامِي. وَامْسَحْ
بِفَضْلِ مَا فِي يَدَيْكَ مِنَ الْمَاءِ رَأْسَكَ وَرِجْلَيْكَ إِلَى كَعْبَيْكَ • وَعَلِمَهُ الْمَسْحَ

برأسيه ورجليه. وقال: إِنِّي أُرِيدُ أَنْ أُمَسِّحَ رَأْسَكَ وَأُبَارِكَ عَلَيْكَ ۖ فَأَمَّا الْمَسْحُ عَلَى رِجْلَيْكَ ۖ فَإِنِّي أُرِيدُ أَنْ أُوْطِئَكَ مَوْطِئًا لَمْ يَطَّأَهُ أَحَدٌ مِنْ قَبْلِكَ ۖ وَلَا يَطَّوُّهُ أَحَدٌ غَيْرُكَ. فهذا علَّةُ الوضوء.

Qāla lī Rabbī ta‘ālā: “Yā Muḥammad, mudd yadaka fa-yatalaqqāka mā’un yasīlu min sāqi l-‘arshi l-ayman.”
Fa-nazala l-mā’ fa-talāqqaytuhu bi-l-yamīn. Fa-min ajli dhālika šāra awwalu l-wuḍū’ al-yumnā.

Thumma qāla: “Yā Muḥammad, khudh dhālika l-mā’ fa-ghsil bihi wajhaka wa-‘allimhu ghasla l-wajh, fa-innaka turīdu an tanzura ilā ‘azamatī wa-anta ṭāhir.
Thumma ghsi l-dhirā’ayn al-yamīn wa-l-yasār wa-‘allimhu dhālika fa-innaka turīdu an tatalaqqā bi-yadayka kalāmī.
Wa-msaḥ bifaḍli mā fī yadayka mina l-mā’ ra’saka wa-rijlayka ilā ka’bayk wa-‘allimhu l-maṣḥa bi-ra’sihi wa-rijlayh.”

Wa-qāla: “Innī urīdu an amsaḥ ra’saka wa-ubārika ‘alayk.
Fa-ammā l-maṣḥu ‘alā rijlayka fa-innī urīdu an uwattī’aka mawṭī’an lam yaṭa’hu aḥadun min qablika wa-lā yaṭa’uhu aḥadun ghayruk.”

Fahādhā ‘illatu l-wuḍū’.

My Lord — Exalted is He — said to me: “O Muḥammad, stretch out your hand so that water may meet you, flowing from the right side of the Throne.”

Then the water descended, and I received it with my right hand. Because of that, the beginning of wuḍū’ was made with the right side.

Then He said: “O Muḥammad, take that water and wash your face with it, and teach [your nation] the washing of the face — for indeed, you seek to gaze upon My Majesty while you are in a state of purity.

Then wash your right and left arms, and teach that — for you seek to receive My words with your hands.

Then wipe your head and your feet to the ankles with the leftover water in your hands, and teach him [your nation] the wiping of the head and the feet.”

And He said: “Indeed, I wish to wipe your head and bless you. As for the wiping of your feet, I desire to place you upon a ground

that no one before you has ever stepped on, and no one other than you shall tread it.”

That is the reason for wuḍū’.

[Shaykh al-Ṣadūq, ‘Ilāl al-Sharāyi’, (Iraq, Najaf: al-Maktabat al-Hiydariyyah, 1966) vol. 2, 314, no. 1]

Thus, we can realise that wudu' is full of lessons and secrets, many of which can be understood through studying narrations, although there are still many more that we do not yet understand.